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Module: Windows Forensics 1

Module link

Module Badge

The screenshot shows a Mozilla Firefox browser window with the URL `tryhackme.com/room/windowsforensics1/congratulations?step=records`. The page has a dark theme and displays a congratulatory message for completing the 'Windows Forensics 1' module. The message includes a laptop icon with a magnifying glass and a shield, and a table showing the user's progress.

Share your win with your peers
Your progress can inspire others in your community.

Windows Forensics 1 completed!
evansnjiru5 completed another room on their cyber security journey.

Completed tasks	Points earned	Streak
11	216	2

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Share your win before starting the next room

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Windows Forensics 1

Registry Hives: Understanding the five main root keys (like HKLM and HKCU) and the physical location of registry hive files in C:\Windows\System32\Config.

- **Offline Analysis:** Learning how to acquire registry hives from a suspect system and analyze them using forensic tools without modifying the original data.
- **Forensic Artifacts:** Identifying specific registry keys that track user behavior, such as RecentDocs, UserAssist, and ShellBags.

Core Forensic Artifacts Covered

Artifact Category	Description	Key Registry Path / Hive
System Info	OS version, computer name, and timezone.	SYSTEM & SOFTWARE
User Accounts	Username, login counts, and password hints.	SAM
File/Folder Usage	Tracks recently opened files and folder view settings.	NTUSER.DAT (RecentDocs)
Execution Evidence	Records of programs run, including execution count and paths.	UserAssist, ShimCache, AmCache
External Devices	History of USB devices connected to the system.	SYSTEM (USBSTOR)

Recommended Tools

The room primarily utilizes Eric Zimmerman's Tools (EZtools), which are industry standards for digital forensics:

- **Registry Explorer:** Used for loading and searching registry hives with automatic parsing of timestamps.
- **ShellBags Explorer:** Specifically designed to view the history of folders accessed by a user.
- **RegRipper:** A CLI tool for extracting specific forensic data into text reports.

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Room progress (80%)

Scenario:

One of the Desktops in the research lab at Organization X is suspected to have been accessed by someone unauthorized. Although they generally have only one user account per Desktop, there were multiple user accounts observed on this system. It is also suspected that the system was connected to some network drive, and a USB device was connected to the system. The triage data from the system was collected and placed on the attached VM. Can you help Organization X with finding answers to the below questions?

Note: When loading registry hives in RegistryExplorer, it will caution us that the hives are dirty. This is nothing to be afraid of. We just need to remember the little lesson about transaction logs and point RegistryExplorer to the .LOG1 and .LOG2 files with the same filename as the registry hive. It will automatically integrate the transaction logs and create a 'clean' hive. Once we tell RegistryExplorer where to save the clean hive, we can use that for our analysis and we won't need to load the dirty hives anymore. RegistryExplorer will guide you through this process.

Answer the questions below

How many user created accounts are present on the system?

3

✓ Correct Answer

Need a specific next step?

Check

Registry Explorer v1.6.0.0

File Tools Options Bookmarks (1/0) View Help

Registry hives (1) | Common (1)

Enter text to search...

Find

Key name

Value

Drag a column header here to go

Key: C:\Windows\system...

Value: (default)

Value type: RegUnknown (0x...)

Value: 00-00-00-00

Raw value: 00-00-00-00

Selected hive: SAM

Last write: 2021-11-24 18:39:15

1 of 1 values shown (100.00%)

Load complete

Hidden keys: 0 | 2

win4n6-2-badr

8:10 PM 3/31/2026

52min 28s

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Room progress (80%)

Scenario:

someone unauthorized. Although they generally have only one user account per Desktop, there were multiple user accounts observed on this system. It is also suspected that the system was connected to some network drive, and a USB device was connected to the system. The triage data from the system was collected and placed on the attached VM. Can you help Organization X with finding answers to the below questions?

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Answer the questions below

How many user created accounts are present on the system?

3

✓ Correct Answer

What is the username of the account that has never been logged in?

thm...

Check

Registry Explorer v1.6.0.0

File Tools Options Bookmarks (1/0) View Help

Registry hives (1) | Available bookmarks (1/0)

Enter text to search...

Find

Key name

Value

Drag a column header here to go

Key: C:\Windows\system...

Value: (default)

Value type: Binary viewer

Value name: (default)

Value type: RegUnknown (0x...)

Value: 00-00-00-00

Raw value: 00-00-00-00

Selected hive: SAM

Last write: 2021-11-24 18:39:15

1 of 1 values shown (100.00%)

Load complete

Hidden keys: 0 | 2

win4n6-2-badr

8:13 PM 3/31/2026

49min 34s

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Registry Explorer v1.6.0.0

File Tools Options Bookmarks (30/0) View Help

Load hive Ctrl+O

Live system

Unload all hives Alt+O

Project

Export 'Registry hives'

Exit

Appsvcs

Console

Control Panel

Environment

ELIUC

Keyboard Layout

Microsoft

Network

Printers

SOFTWARE

System

Associated deleted records

ROOT

Unassociated deleted records

Startmenu

UnAssociations

shell

Unassociated deleted values

Default NTUSER.DAT

Default UserClass.dat

Public NTUSER.DAT

Public UserClass.dat

THM-4n6 NTUSER.DAT

THM-4n6 UserClass.dat

thm-user NTUSER.DAT

thm-user UserClass.dat

Values

Drag a column header here to group by that column

Value Name	Value Type	Data	Value Slack	Is Deleted	Data Record Reallocated

Type viewer

Key: ROOT

Selected hive: ntuser.dat Last write: 2026-03-31 15:04:53 Key contains no values Load complete

Hidden keys: 0 14

Type here to search

win4n6-2-badr

29min 27s

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Registry Explorer v1.6.0.0

File Tools Options Bookmarks (1/0) View Help

Registry hives (1) Available bookmarks (1/0)

Enter text to search... Find

Key name	# values	# subkeys	Last write timestamp
C:\Windows\system32\config\SAM			
ROOT	0	1	2021-11-24 18:17:47
SAM	2	3	2021-11-24 18:19:19
Domains	1	2	2021-11-24 18:17:47
Account	2	3	2021-11-25 17:05:49
Aliases	1	2	2021-11-24 18:17:47
Groups	1	2	2021-11-24 18:17:47
Users	1	8	2021-11-24 18:39:15
000001F4	2	0	2021-11-24 18:17:47
000001F5	2	0	2021-11-24 18:17:47
000001F7	3	0	2021-11-24 18:17:47
000001F8	4	0	2021-11-24 18:17:47
000003E9	4	0	2026-03-31 15:04:52
000003EA	3	0	2021-11-24 18:39:50
000003EB	3	0	2021-11-24 18:39:15
Names	1	7	2021-11-24 18:39:15
Administrator	1	0	2021-11-24 18:17:47
DefaultAccount	1	0	2021-11-24 18:17:47
Guest	1	0	2021-11-24 18:17:47
THM-4n6	1	0	2021-11-24 18:17:47
thm-user	1	0	2021-11-24 18:36:29
thm-user2	1	0	2021-11-24 18:39:15
WDAGUtilityAccount	1	0	2021-11-24 18:17:47
Builtin	3	3	2021-11-24 18:39:15
LastSkuUpgrade	1	0	2021-11-24 18:19:19
RXACT	1	0	2021-11-24 18:17:47

Values

Drag a column header here to group by that column

Value Name	Value Type	Data	Value Slack	Is Deleted	Data Record Reallocated
(default)	RegUnknown	00-00-00-00			

Type viewer

Binary viewer

Value name (default)

Value type RegUnknown (0x3E9, 1001 decimal)

Value 00-00-00-00

Raw value 00-00-00-00

Key: SAM\Domains\Account\Users\Names\THM-4n6

Selected hive: SAM Last write: 2021-11-24 18:17:47 1 of 1 values shown (100.00%) Load complete

Hidden keys: 0 16

Type here to search

win4n6-2-badr

19min 43s

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Registry Explorer v1.6.0.0

File Tools Options Bookmarks (1/0) View Help

Registry hives (1) Available bookmarks (1/0)

Enter text to search... Find

Key name # values # subkeys Last write timestamp

- C:\Windows\system32\config\SAM
 - ROOT 0 1 2021-11-24 18:17:47
 - SAM 2 3 2021-11-24 18:19:19
 - Domains 1 2 2021-11-24 18:17:47
 - Account 2 3 2021-11-25 17:05:49
 - Aliases 1 2 2021-11-24 18:17:47
 - Groups 1 2 2021-11-24 18:17:47
 - Users 1 8 2021-11-24 18:39:15
 - Builtin 3 3 2021-11-24 18:39:15
 - LastSkuUpgrade 1 0 2021-11-24 18:19:19
 - RXACT 1 0 2021-11-24 18:17:47

Values User accounts

Drag a column header here to group by that column

Us...	Inv...	Tot...	Cr...	Las...	Las...	Ex...	Us...	Full...	Gr...	Co...	Us...	Int...	Ac...	Ho...	Pa...	Te...	No...	Mn...	Int...	Wo...	Ser...	Pa...	Aut...
1001	0	30	20...	20...	20...	20...	Th...	4n6	count	Admi	nistr	ators											
1002	0	2	20...	20...			thm-		null	User	s												
1003	0	0	20...				thm-		null	User	s												

Total rows: 7 Export ?

Type viewer Binary viewer

Value name (default)

Value type RegLink

Value

Raw value

Key: SAM\Domains\Account\Users

Selected hive: SAM Last write: 2021-11-24 18:39:15 1 of 1 values shown (100.00%) Load complete

Hidden keys: 0 16

Type here to search

win4n6-2-badr

1h 16min 0s

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Registry Explorer v1.6.0.0

File Tools Options Bookmarks (30/0) View Help

Registry hives (2) Available bookmarks (12/0)

Enter text to search... Find

Key name # values # subkeys Last write timestamp

- C:\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\RecentDocs*.txt
 - FeatureUsage 1 5 2022-01-04 16:16:59
 - FileExts 0 203 2026-03-31 15:28:10
 - HideDesktopIcons 0 1 2021-11-24 18:18:58
 - LogonState 2 0 2021-11-24 18:23:37
 - LowRegistry 0 0 2021-11-24 18:23:43
 - MenuOrder 0 1 2021-11-24 18:19:54
 - Modules 0 3 2021-11-24 18:25:44
 - MountPoints2 0 5 2021-11-24 18:27:04
 - OperationStatusManager 1 0 2021-11-24 18:26:02
 - Package Installation 1 0 2022-01-04 16:15:54
 - RecentDocs 18 6 2026-03-31 15:28:10
 - .DAT 2 0 2026-03-31 15:26:00
 - .DAT_clean 2 0 2026-03-31 15:28:10
 - .ps1 2 0 2021-11-24 18:18:48
 - .txt 3 0 2026-03-31 15:19:02
 - .xml 2 0 2021-11-30 10:56:21
 - Folder 8 0 2026-03-31 15:26:00
 - Ribbon 2 0 2021-11-24 18:20:02
 - RunMRU 0 0 2021-11-24 18:18:48
 - SearchPlatform 0 1 2021-11-24 18:18:40
 - Shell Folders 31 0 2021-11-24 18:23:47
 - Shutdown 1 0 2025-11-15 13:08:30
 - StartPage 2 0 2021-11-24 18:20:02
 - StartupApproved 0 2 2022-01-04 15:53:35
 - Streams 0 1 2021-11-24 18:20:02
 - StuDirRects3 1 0 2026-03-31 15:05:52
 - TabletMode 1 0 2021-11-24 18:24:10

Values Recent documents

Drag a column header here to group by that column

Extension	Value Name	Target Name	Lnk Name	Mru Position	Opened On	Extension Last Opened
.txt	1	2021-12-01T130817_Co	2021-12-01T130817_Co			
.txt	0	ChangeLog.txt	ChangeLog.lnk	1	2026-03-31 15:19:02	

Total rows: 2 Export ?

Type viewer

00 01 02 03 04 05 06 07 08 09 0A 0B 0C 0D 0E 0F 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18

00000000 01 00 00 00 00 00 00 00 FF FF FF FF

Current offset: 0 (0x0) Bytes selected: 0 (0x0)

Data interpreter ?

Value: MRUListEx Collapse all hives

Hidden keys: 0 22

Type here to search

win4n6-2-badr

1h 6min 2s

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Registry Explorer v1.6.0.0

File Tools Options Bookmarks (30/0) View Help

Registry hives (1) Available bookmarks (31/0)

Enter text to search... Find

Key name # values # subkeys Last wr

RecentDocs

Values Recent documents

Drag a column header here to group by that column

Extension	Value Name	Target Name	Link Name	Mru Position	Opened On	Extension Last Opened
RecentDocs	7	EZtools	EZtools.Link	0	2021-12-01 13:00:34	
RecentDocs	6	Settings	Settings.Link	1	2021-11-30 10:56:23	
RecentDocs	5	WallpaperSettings.xml	WallpaperSettings.Link	2	2021-11-30 10:56:21	
RecentDocs	4	System and Security	System and Security.Link	3		
RecentDocs	3	System	System.Link	4		
RecentDocs	1	KAPE	KAPE.Link	5		
RecentDocs	0	Get-KAPEUpdate.ps1	Get-KAPEUpdate.Link	6	2021-11-24 18:18:48	
RecentDocs	2	Changelog.txt	Changelog.Link	7	2021-11-24 18:18:48	
Folder	2	Settings	Settings.Link	0	2021-11-30 10:56:23	
Folder	1	System and Security	System and Security.Link	1		
Folder	0	KAPE	KAPE.Link	2		
.xml	0	WallpaperSettings.xml	WallpaperSettings.Link	0	2021-11-30 10:56:21	
.txt	0	Changelog.txt	Changelog.Link	0	2021-11-24 18:18:48	
.ps1	0	Get-KAPEUpdate.ps1	Get-KAPEUpdate.Link	0	2021-11-24 18:18:48	

Total rows: 14

Type viewer

Current offset: 0 (0x0) Bytes selected: 0 (0x0)

Data interpreter ?

Value: MRUListEx Collapse all hives

Hidden keys: 0

9:15 PM 3/31/2026

win4n6-2-badr

47min 12s

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Registry Explorer v1.6.0.0

File Tools Options Bookmarks (30/0) View Help

Registry hives (1) Available bookmarks (31/0)

Enter text to search... Find

Key name # values # subkeys Last wr

UserAssist

Values User Assist

Drag a column header here to group by that column

Program Name	Run Counter	Focus Count	Focus Time	Last Executed
D:\setup64.exe	1	1	3 0d, 0h, 00m, 32s	2021-11-25 03:21:31
Microsoft.Windows.WindowsInstall	0	1	1 0d, 0h, 00m, 04s	
Z:\setups\7z1900-x64.exe	1	0	0 0d, 0h, 00m, 00s	2021-11-25 03:26:39
\\vmware-host\shared Folders\setups\7z1900-x64.exe	0	1	0 0d, 0h, 00m, 13s	
Z:\setups\Firefox Installer.exe	1	0	0 0d, 0h, 00m, 00s	2021-11-25 03:27:03
\\vmware-host\shared Folders\setups\Firefox Installer.exe	0	0	0 0d, 0h, 00m, 00s	
C:\Users\THM-4n6\AppData\Local\Temp\72509BA-49F3\setup-stub.exe	0	1	0 0d, 0h, 01m, 20s	
Z:\setups\python-3.8.2.exe	1	0	0 0d, 0h, 00m, 00s	2021-11-25 03:32:00
C:\Users\THM-4n6\AppData\Local\Temp\Unmapped GUID: B405886A-9CC3-4639-9E0C-0B3E1DE0C040\python-3.8.2.exe	0	1	0 0d, 0h, 00m, 16s	
E:\CF126E110C2118	2	2	0d, 0h, 01m, 43s	2021-12-01 12:32:34

Total rows: 49

Type viewer Slack viewer

Current offset: 0 (0x0) Bytes selected: 0 (0x0)

Data interpreter ?

Value: HRZR_PGVHPNPbagpgbge Collapse all hives

Hidden keys: 0

9:20 PM 3/31/2026

win4n6-2-badr

42min 20s

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Registry Explorer v1.6.0.0

File Tools Options Bookmarks (30/0) View Help

Registry hives (3) Available bookmarks (92/0)

Enter text to search... Find

Key name	# values	# subkeys	Last write
UMB	0	1	202
USB	0	10	202
ROOT_HUB	0	1	202
582891968b80	12	2	202
Device Parameters	1	1	202
Properties	0	6	202
ROOT_HUB20	0	1	202
ROOT_HUB30	0	1	202
VID_0930&PID_6545	0	1	202
VID_0E0F&PID_0002	0	3	202
VID_0E0F&PID_0003	0	1	202
VID_0E0F&PID_0003&M1_00	0	1	202
VID_0E0F&PID_0003&M1_01	0	1	202
VID_0E0F&PID_0008	0	1	202
VID_2537&PID_1068	0	1	202
USBSTOR	0	2	202
Disk&Ven_Kingston&Prod_DataTraveler_2.0&Rev_PMAP	0	1	202
Disk&Ven_USB3.0&Prod_External_Device&Rev_SDM1	0	1	202
0123456789ABCDEF80	12	2	202
XENBUS	0	3	202
XENVIF	0	1	202
Hardware Profiles	0	2	202
0000	0	2	201
0001	0	2	202
Policies	0	0	202
Services	0	742	202

Values USBSTOR

Drag a column header here to group by that column

Timestamp	Manufacturer	Title	Version	Disk Id	Serial Number	Device Name	Installed	First Installed	Last Connected	Last Removed
2021-11-24 1...	Ven_Kingston	Prod_DataTraveler_2.0	Rev_PMAP	{e251921f-4da2-11ec-a783-01a7dda7110}	1CAF654E59A3B0C179D366AE80	Kingston DataTraveler 2.0 USB Device	2021-11-24 1...	2021-11-24 1...	2021-11-24 18:40:06	
2021-11-24 1...	Ven_USB3.0	Prod_External_Device	Rev_SDM1	{f529a946-4d9e-11ec-a782-01a7dda7110}	0123456789ABCDEF80	USB3.0 External Device USB Device	2021-11-24 1...	2021-11-24 1...	2021-11-24 1...	

Total rows: 2

Type viewer

Key: ControlSet001\Enum\USBSTOR

Value: None

Collapse all hives

Selected hive: SYSTEM

Last write: 2021-11-24 18:27:02

Key contains no values

Copied Last write time to clipboard

Hidden keys: 0

10:29 PM 3/31/2026

33min 8s